



Plant focus: grasses and sedges

Elegant and versatile, the slender foliage and airy flowers of grasses and sedges contrast beautifully with broad-leaved plants.

ORNAMENTAL GRASSES AND SEDGES COMPRISE A RANGE OF SHAPES AND SIZES, from tall and slender to short and squat, and form the key ingredient of many garden styles. Those with slim leaves and delicate flower heads, such as reed grass, blend perfectly into naturalistic schemes, while the spikes of blue fescue are ideal for container displays. Sedges, including those in the *Acorus* family, make elegant features in the boggy ground beside natural water features. Although sedges and grasses look similar, they are adapted to different environments. With a few exceptions, grasses are deciduous and prefer sun and free-draining soils, while the majority of sedges are evergreen and happy in sun or shade and moist soils. Grasses also tend to have more dramatic flower- and seedheads adding to their decorative value. Both grasses and sedges help to heighten the beauty of winter landscapes: the leaves of deciduous species tend to remain intact throughout the season, providing useful structure in herbaceous borders.

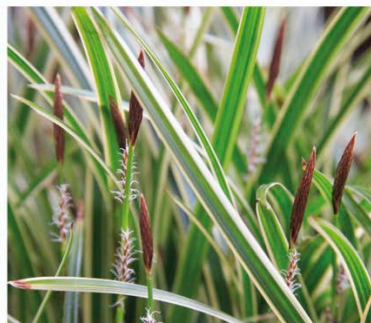
POPULAR GRASS AND SEDGE SPECIES



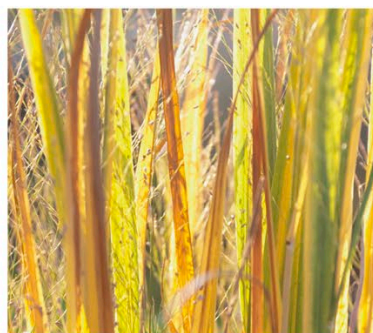
Acorus Sweet flags are moisture-loving evergreen sedges and thrive in shade. They include striped and golden-leaved forms.



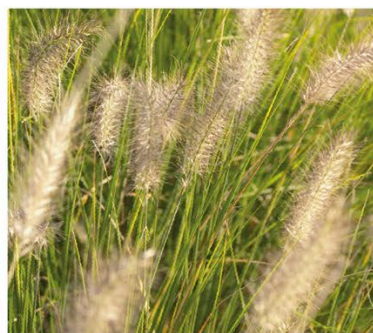
Calamagrostis Deciduous feather reed grasses produce low clumps of leaves teamed with tall stems of feathery summer flowers.



Carex This group of evergreen and deciduous sedges includes moisture-lovers, shade-tolerant varieties, and bronze forms that prefer drier soils.



Panicum The most popular form is *P. virgatum*, a deciduous perennial grass with blue, red, or purple-tinted foliage.



Pennisetum Long, bristlelike flower heads and mounds of slender leaves are features of this deciduous grass; some forms are tender.



Stipa Often used interchangeably with *Nassella*, many of these grasses feature feathery inflorescence from early summer to autumn.

USING GRASSES AND SEDGES

Grasses are used in prairie-style schemes for their summer foliage and flowers and winter structure. Use sedges for year-round color and interest at the front of a bed.



Short compact grasses, including the vivid Japanese forest grass, create graphic displays in pots. Evergreen sedges are ideal for winter displays.



Tall slim-leaved grasses, such as feather reed grass, make bold accents in mixed herbaceous borders, while their transparency allows welcome glimpses of the plants behind.

Bronze forms of *Carex* and airy Mexican feather grass provide contrasting textures and colors to flower displays in both modern and traditional garden designs.